

The Arbiter's Awakening

Chapter 14: The Mentor

Day 44 Since Awakening - 23:47

Hayami was reviewing the Advanced Fire Manipulation Manual, preparing for tomorrow's training session, when every sense they possessed suddenly screamed in alarm.

Someone was in their apartment.

Not breaking in. Not entering. Just... there. As if they'd always been there, occupying space that should have been empty.

Hayami spun around, lightning crackling across their hands, earth responding to their alarm by making the floor ripple slightly. Their Enhanced Perception, amplified by Perfect Awareness, should have detected any intruder long before they got close. But this presence had simply appeared, bypassing every defensive sense Hayami possessed.

The figure stood near the window—or perhaps beside the door—or maybe in the center of the room. Their position seemed to shift depending on where Hayami looked, as if they existed in multiple places simultaneously. They wore a cloak that absorbed light, making it impossible to discern their features or even their basic shape. The fabric moved like liquid shadow, like wind given form, like concepts made manifest.

"Peace, young Arbiter." The voice came from everywhere and nowhere, neither male nor female, neither young nor old. It resonated not in Hayami's ears but in their bones, in the elements themselves. "I mean you no harm."

Hayami's hand moved to Storm Fang's hilt. "Who are you? How did you get in here?"

"Questions with complicated answers." The figure shifted—or perhaps Hayami's perception shifted—and suddenly they seemed closer, though they hadn't moved. "I am nameless. A Primordial Force. The concept given consciousness, the cycle made aware."

The words triggered something in Hayami's System. Notifications appeared, golden and urgent:

[SYSTEM ALERT] [PRIMORDIAL PRESENCE DETECTED] [ANALYZING...]

[ENTITY IDENTIFIED: PRIMORDIAL FORCE (NAMELESS)] [CLASSIFICATION: CONCEPT-CLASS BEING] [THREAT LEVEL: INCALCULABLE] [INTENT: NON-HOSTILE]

Hayami didn't relax, but they didn't attack either. "Primordial Force. Like the Primordial Cycle?"

"The Cycle is me. I am the Cycle. We are one and separate, eternal and momentary." The figure's cloak rippled with colors that shouldn't exist—colors Hayami's enhanced perception could barely process. "You have been

Awakened as its Arbiter. The first in three thousand years."

"Three thousand—" Hayami's mind reeled. "Arbiters have existed before?"

"Seven times across human history. Each one masters the seven elements, brings balance to the cycle, then passes on." The nameless presence seemed to consider Hayami, though they had no visible eyes. "You are the eighth. Still weak. Still learning. But improving at a rate that caught my attention."

"The System," Hayami said slowly, pieces clicking together. "The daily quests, the reward boxes, the elemental progression. That's you?"

"The System is... a framework. A method of communication between your mortal consciousness and the fundamental forces of existence. I did not create it—your world's Awakening did that. But I have... influenced it. Guided it toward recognizing an Arbiter when one emerged."

The figure moved—or reality moved around them—and suddenly they were standing directly in front of Hayami. Close enough to touch. The cloak's edge brushed against the floor, and where it touched, the concrete briefly became stone, then water, then flame, cycling through elemental states.

"You have mastered three elements in forty-four days. Achieved B-rank in all three. This is... unprecedented. Even previous Arbiters required years." Something like approval colored the impossible voice. "You have the dedication. The discipline. The hunger for growth."

"Why are you here?" Hayami kept their voice steady despite the surreal nature of the conversation. "What do you want?"

"To offer guidance. To ensure this iteration of the Arbiter succeeds where others have failed." The figure extended something—a hand, perhaps, though it was hard to tell where the cloak ended and the being began. "The path to mastering seven elements is long and treacherous. Many abandon it. Some die attempting it. Others lose themselves in power."

"And you want to prevent that?"

"I want the Cycle to continue. For that, I need an Arbiter who can bear the weight of all seven elements without breaking." The extended appendage touched Hayami's forehead, and suddenly their System interface exploded with new notifications.

[SYSTEM INTEGRATION IN PROGRESS]

[PRIMORDIAL FORCE (NAMELESS) REQUESTING MENTOR ACCESS]

[WARNING: This will allow the Primordial Force to observe your progress, provide guidance, and potentially intervene in critical situations. They will have limited access to System functions for your benefit.]

[ACCEPT MENTORSHIP?] [YES] / [NO]

Hayami stared at the prompt. A mentor. A being of impossible power offering to guide them through the Arbiter path. It felt too convenient, too strange.

"What do you get out of this?" Hayami asked bluntly. "There's always a price."

"Perceptive." The figure seemed pleased. "I gain an Arbiter who completes the Cycle. When all seven elements reach mastery, when the path is walked to its end, balance is restored to the fundamental forces. This benefits me because I am those forces. Your success is my success."

"And if I refuse?"

"You continue as you have been. Alone. Learning through trial and error. Possibly succeeding, more likely failing." The cloak rippled. "I offer knowledge, not power. Guidance, not control. The choice to walk the path remains yours. I merely light the way."

Hayami thought about the journey so far. Forty-four days of brutal training, near-death experiences, betrayals, and grinding progression. They'd figured out the elemental masteries through experimentation and the Training Manuals. But having someone—something—that understood the path ahead could be invaluable.

And if this being wanted to harm them, they could have done so already. The threat level was listed as "incalculable"—if the Primordial Force wanted Hayami dead, they'd be dead.

"What kind of guidance are we talking about?"

"Advice on elemental progression. Warnings about common pitfalls. Insights into how elements interact at higher mastery levels. Occasional interventions if you face death." The figure paused. "And most importantly—knowledge of what comes after. What an Arbiter truly is, once all seven elements are mastered."

That caught Hayami's attention. "No one's told me what the endgame is. The System just says to master elements and fulfill the Arbiter role."

"Because mortal language fails to describe it. But when the time comes, when you stand at the threshold of completion, I will help you understand." The nameless presence withdrew slightly. "I do not ask for servitude. Only for the opportunity to guide one who shows promise of completing a path that has gone unfinished for three millennia."

Hayami looked at the prompt again. Mentor access. Observation. Guidance. Intervention.

They thought about Himiko's question from earlier: what comes after?

Having someone who knew the answer—even if that someone was a cryptic cosmic entity—felt necessary.

"If I accept, can I remove the mentorship later if I don't like it?"

"At any time. Your will supersedes mine in matters of the System."

"And you won't try to control me or force me down specific paths?"

"I cannot. The Arbiter must choose their own way. I can only illuminate options."

Hayami took a breath, then selected [YES].

[MENTORSHIP ACCEPTED]

[PRIMORDIAL FORCE (NAMELESS) REGISTERED AS MENTOR]

[SYSTEM INTEGRATION COMPLETE]

[NEW FEATURES UNLOCKED:]

- **Mentor Guidance:** Receive occasional advice and insights from your mentor
- **Elemental Consultation:** Ask questions about element mastery and progression
- **Critical Intervention:** In life-threatening situations, mentor may provide emergency assistance (limited to 3 uses)
- **Cycle Vision:** Periodic glimpses of the Arbiter's true purpose

[MENTOR REGISTERED IN RELATIONSHIPS]

- Primordial Force (Nameless): Mentor - Relationship: Formal/Professional

The figure seemed to solidify slightly, becoming fractionally more present in reality. "A wise choice. Your instincts serve you well—trust them. Question everything, including me."

"I will," Hayami said dryly. "So, mentor. Any immediate advice?"

"Fire is passion made manifest. You have mastered lightning's fury, earth's patience, and wind's freedom. Fire is different—it consumes, transforms, destroys to create. Approach it with respect, not just control." The cloak rippled with ember-like colors. "And be careful in tomorrow's raid. Not everything is as it seems."

"That's ominously vague."

"Specific predictions create self-fulfilling prophecies. I warn only of potential, not certainty." The Primordial Force began to fade, their presence becoming less defined. "We will speak again when you reach significant milestones. Until then, continue your path. You are progressing well."

"Wait—" Hayami started, but the figure was already gone. Not departed, not fled. Simply... not there anymore, as if they'd never existed at all.

Except the System notification remained, confirming what had just happened.

**[MENTOR: PRIMORDIAL FORCE (NAMELESS)] [STATUS: AVAILABLE FOR CONSULTATION]
[CURRENT GUIDANCE: "Approach fire with respect, not just control."]**

Hayami sat down heavily on their bed, processing the encounter. A Primordial Force. A nameless cosmic entity representing the elemental cycle itself. Now registered as their mentor in the System.

This was their life now. Secret B-rank power at Level 30, four elements unlocked, three at B-rank, and apparently cosmic entities taking personal interest in their development.

"What the hell have I gotten into?" Hayami muttered to the empty apartment.

The System didn't answer. But in their peripheral vision, they could swear they saw the Crown of the Arbiter's four gemstones pulse once, as if in acknowledgment.

Hayami checked the time: 12:03 AM. They'd need to wake up in five hours for the daily quest, then meet Himiko for breakfast at 8 AM.

Sleep. They needed sleep.

But first, one more thing. Hayami pulled up their relationship status:

[RELATIONSHIPS]

- Himiko Nakayama: Best Friend/Partner (A-rank, shapeshifter, deeply trusted)
- Sato Kenji: Professional Contact (C-rank, reliable, guild-affiliated)
- Primordial Force (Nameless): Mentor (Concept-class being, advisor for Arbiter path)

An A-rank friend, a C-rank professional contact, and a cosmic entity mentor.

Hayami's life had gotten very strange, very fast.

They set their alarm and finally went to sleep, too exhausted to process the implications fully. Tomorrow would bring breakfast, a raid, and probably more revelations.

The grind continued. But now, apparently, with cosmic oversight.

The daily quest had been routine—twenty-two consecutive days of Beyond the Limit achievement, another four points to all stats. Hayami had showered, dressed in their combat gear (appearing as basic equipment thanks to Phantom Mode), and headed to meet Himiko.

The breakfast place she'd chosen was a small, traditional restaurant tucked between modern buildings in Shibuya. Hayami arrived two minutes early and found Himiko already there, sitting at a table near the window and waving enthusiastically.

"Morning!" Himiko was disgustingly chipper for 8 AM. "I already ordered for both of us—tamagoyaki set, miso soup, and rice. Trust me, it's amazing."

Hayami slid into the seat across from her. "Morning. You seem energized."

"I love raids! Even when they're dangerous, there's something exciting about it." Himiko leaned forward conspiratorially. "Also, I leveled up yesterday from solo training. Hit Level 17!"

"Nice. What'd you work on?"

"Partial transformations. I can do just hands and feet now, which is way more useful than full-body shifts in some situations." She demonstrated by briefly shifting one hand into bird talons, then back to human. "Still costs mana, but way less than before."

The food arrived—perfectly cooked rolled omelet, steaming soup, fluffy white rice. They ate while discussing the upcoming raid.

"So the party leader is named Takeda," Himiko said between bites. "C-rank, Level 42, specializes in sword combat. He's assembling a six-person team for a C-rank Gate called Iron Depths. Lots of metal-type monsters apparently."

"Metal types." Hayami considered. Lightning would be effective against metal. Earth could manipulate it if they expanded their control. Wind less useful. Fire could heat and weaken it. "Good matchup for us."

"That's what I thought! Your lightning and my shapeshifting should handle most threats." Himiko paused, her expression becoming more serious. "Hey, can I ask you something?"

"Sure."

"Last night, did you... feel anything weird? Like, I don't know, a presence or something?" Himiko looked uncomfortable. "Around midnight, I got this overwhelming sensation that something was watching me. Really powerful. It freaked me out."

Hayami's hand tightened on their chopsticks. The Primordial Force. If Himiko had sensed it...

"A-ranks have sharper instincts," Hayami said carefully. "You probably picked up on some ambient mana fluctuation or a high-rank Hunter passing through the area."

"Maybe." Himiko didn't sound convinced. "It felt more... intentional. Like whatever it was, was specifically looking for something." She shook off the mood. "Anyway, probably nothing. Just got spooked."

They finished breakfast and headed to the Gate meeting point. Hayami's System pinged with a notification:

[MENTOR GUIDANCE] [Your companion sensed my presence. A-rank instincts are formidable. Consider whether to reveal mentorship—trust is valuable, but so is discretion.]

Hayami dismissed the notification. They'd tell Himiko eventually, but not right before a raid. Too many questions, not enough time.

09:54 - Iron Depths Gate Checkpoint

The gate was in an industrial district, surrounded by warehouses and factories. The Gate itself pulsed with a metallic silver-gray light, and Hayami could hear faint sounds of grinding and clanging emanating from it.

[GATE #TY-447: IRON DEPTHS] [RANK: C] [ESTIMATED DIFFICULTY: C+]

Four other Hunters were already assembled. The party leader—Takeda—was a tall man in his thirties with a no-nonsense bearing and a katana strapped to his back. The other three consisted of two C-rank damage dealers and one C-rank healer.

Takeda looked up as Hayami and Himiko approached, his eyes immediately going to Himiko's license.

"Nakayama? The A-rank?"

"That's me." Himiko smiled. "And this is Amamiya, my partner."

Takeda's gaze shifted to Hayami's E-rank license, and his expression became skeptical. "E-rank. In a C-rank Gate. You sure about this?"

"I've done multiple C-rank raids," Hayami said evenly. "Including one with a B-rank boss. I can handle it."

"With an A-rank carrying you, maybe." One of the damage dealers—a woman with twin hammers—spoke up. "No offense, but E-ranks in C-rank content usually just get in the way or die."

"I won't do either," Hayami replied calmly.

Himiko stepped forward, her usual cheerful demeanor shifting to something more serious. "Amamiya is the most capable Hunter I've worked with. E-rank or not, they're an asset. If you don't want them on the team, we both walk."

The party went silent. Takeda studied both of them, clearly weighing the value of having an A-rank versus the risk of an E-rank. Finally, he nodded.

"Fine. But you stay in support positions, both of you. Handle stragglers, watch for ambushes, don't engage the main groups unless absolutely necessary." He pulled up a tablet. "Standard payment is ¥180,000 each plus loot share. Iron Depths is heavy on metal-type monsters—Iron Golems, Steel Serpents, and possibly a Chromium Titan boss. We clear methodically, we don't take risks, and everyone goes home alive. Clear?"

The team nodded.

"Good. We enter in five minutes. Final equipment checks."

Hayami did a quick inventory review:

- Storm Fang (hidden as basic sword)
- Elemental Fury throwing knives (hidden)
- All legendary equipment active but invisible
- Consumables ready
- Mana: 2,940/2,940

They were as ready as they'd ever be.

Himiko moved closer and whispered, "Thanks for having my back with the E-rank thing."

"You had mine first," Hayami replied. "Partners, remember?"

"Yeah." Himiko smiled. "Partners."

Takeda gave the signal. "Team, form up. We're going in."

They entered the Gate.

**[NOTICE: You have entered a C-Rank Gate] [Gate Name: Iron Depths] [Estimated Difficulty: C+]
[Recommended Level: 35-55]**

The interior was unlike any Gate Hayami had seen before. The walls, floor, and ceiling were all metal—not crafted or shaped, but grown organically like metallic crystal formations. The air smelled of iron and ozone. Every sound echoed with a resonant clang.

"Stay alert," Takeda commanded. "Metal-types are tough and hit hard. Healer, keep shields up on main fighters. Support team, watch our six."

They moved in formation through the metallic corridors. The light was strange—reflecting and refracting off polished surfaces until the entire space seemed to glow with diffused silver light.

The first encounter came within ten minutes.

[IRON GOLEM - LEVEL 38] x4 [HP: 5,200/5,200 each]

Four golems, each standing three meters tall, made entirely of segmented iron plates that moved like joints. Their eyes glowed red, and when they moved, the sound was deafening.

Takeda's team engaged immediately. The two damage dealers went for the legs and joints—weak points where the metal plates connected. The healer provided barriers and minor healing. Takeda himself took the front, his katana enhanced with fire magic that heated the metal to weaken it.

Two golems broke through the formation, heading for the support position.

Hayami and Himiko moved in sync.

Himiko shifted into a large wolf form and intercepted the first golem, her enhanced strength allowing her to grapple with it despite the size difference.

Hayami faced the second golem and immediately assessed its composition. Metal. Excellent conductor of electricity. Perfect target for lightning.

"Master Lightning Strike."

The bolt hit the golem center-mass with B-rank power. Electricity coursed through its metal body, frying internal mechanisms. The golem seized up, sparks flying from its joints, and collapsed.

[IRON GOLEM DEFEATED] [+1,520 EXP]

The main team had finished their three golems and were staring at Hayami. The E-rank who'd just one-shot a Level 38 monster.

"That was..." the hammer-wielder started.

"Lucky shot," Hayami interrupted, deliberately downplaying it. "Metal conducts lightning well. Just capitalized on the weakness."

Takeda narrowed his eyes but nodded. "Good thinking. Keep it up."

They continued deeper into the Gate.

Over the next hour, Hayami and Himiko proved their worth repeatedly. Every straggler that slipped past the main team was handled efficiently. Himiko's shapeshifting adaptability and Hayami's elemental versatility made them an effective duo.

But Hayami kept feeling something off. The Primordial Force's warning echoed in their mind: "Not everything is as it seems."

The Gate was too clean. Too straightforward. C+ difficulty should mean more chaos, more danger. But every encounter had been predictable, almost scripted.

They were approaching the fourth chamber when Hayami's Seismic Sense picked up something wrong. Vibrations in the metal floor that didn't match the party's footsteps. Something large, moving parallel to them through the walls.

"Takeda," Hayami called out quietly. "Something's following us."

The party leader stopped immediately. "Where?"

"In the walls. Something big, pacing us."

Takeda's expression hardened. "The Gate's active boss. It's hunting us." He pulled up his tablet. "This Gate was supposed to be cleared two days ago. If the boss is hunting instead of sleeping, it means—"

The wall exploded inward.

[CHROMIUM COLOSSUS - LEVEL 54] [BOSS MONSTER - B-RANK] [HP: 85,000/85,000]

Not a Chromium Titan. A Colossus. B-rank, not C-rank.

The creature was massive—eight meters tall, made entirely of polished chromium that reflected their horrified faces back at them. It moved with terrible speed for something its size, one massive fist already swinging toward the party.

"SCATTER!" Takeda screamed.

The team dove in different directions. The Colossus's fist hit where they'd been standing, and the metal floor crumpled like paper.

[SYSTEM ALERT] [URGENT QUEST: SURVIVE THE COLOSSUS]

[An unexpected B-rank boss has appeared. Work with your team to defeat it or escape alive.]

[COMPLETION REWARD: +20,000 EXP, Legendary Reward Box, Skill: Metal Manipulation]

[FAILURE PENALTY: DEATH]

The Chromium Colossus roared—a sound like tearing steel—and the real fight began.

[TO BE CONTINUED...]

[CURRENT STATUS]

[LEVEL: 30] [ELEMENTS MASTERED: 3/7] [MENTOR REGISTERED: PRIMORDIAL FORCE (NAMELESS)]

[STATS] (with equipment)

- Strength: 165 (+4 from daily quest)
- Agility: 231 (+4)
- Vitality: 149 (+4)
- Intelligence: 248 (+4)
- Sense: 167 (+4)
- Mana: 2,940/2,940

[CURRENT SITUATION]

- B-rank boss encounter (unexpected)
- Team unprepared for this threat level
- Urgent quest active
- Himiko's safety at risk
- True capabilities may need to be revealed

[END OF CHAPTER 14]